INFOGRAPHIC · TIM MARSHALL, PRISONERS OF GEOGRAPHY

China's development and why Africa's path is different



01
Hu Line
Heihe to Yunan

02
3×
Africa's land area

03
1 in 4
will be African

VOL. 2 · THE SIX POINTS

China

01 Agriculture + geographical features



"This imaginary line is probably the most important geographical feature in this country"

China's heartland is "the political, cultural, demographic and crucially the agricultural centre of gravity". The Hu Line, an imaginary line from Heihe to the province of Yunan, explains the disparity of China's population and how...

SIGNIFICANCE. The most important factor- scales largely and introduced a huge agricultural sector based off climate and fertile land.

02 Borders + buffer zones



"It wants a buffer zone in the border regions to protect it from instability"

China's large geographical expanse means it borders many countries, so it wants buffer zones in the border regions to protect it from instability and possible threats. The buffers act as a deterrent to invaders, which makes it...

SIGNIFICANCE. Political implication: More free money to spend, less political instability, fertile land, layer of protection- the CBD is protected by a large variety of natural buffer zones.

03 Naval exploits + sea navigation



SIMILARITIES

Both are large-scale regions, whose development was determined by their natural geography: natural barriers decided where people could settle, trade and be governed. Both have had to live with buffers, whilst aiding China, Africa as a continent is greatly hindered by this, especially with a lack of networking and independence.

DIFFERENCES

China has one fertile, river-linked heartland walled in by mountains and desert, so it became a single centralised state. Africa's rivers are broken by waterfalls, its coast lacks harbours and its interior is split by desert and jungle, so it stayed fragmented and was later divided again by European borders and general colonialism. China, a country is more centralised and has less divide socially, along with a highly educated, skilled and large workforce allowing it to develop at a faster rate than Africa- not only through geography but other features as well.

Africa

01 Natural barriers



"These are just two in a long list of problems that help explain why Africa isn't as technologically or politically advanced"

Africa's geography is a negative factor. Its great rivers are broken by waterfalls and rapids, so they are poor for transport, and the coast has few natural harbours. It has little connectiveness to European and even Asian...

SIGNIFICANCE. Geography's importance cannot be understated- it is a huge contributor to both political and economic deficiencies.

02 Borders drawn by colonialism + war



"Many Africans are now partially prisoners of the political geography the Europeans made, and of the natural barriers with which nature endowed them"

The borders were drawn by Europeans without respect for ethnic groups, for example in Sudan and Somalia. This promotes violence, from "Africa's world war" in the Congo onwards, and therefore political, social and economic...

SIGNIFICANCE. Imposed borders turned natural division into permanent conflict, blocking the stable centralised state which has been developed by China.

03 Population growth

WHICH WOULD BE BIGGER?

Africa is roughly three times China's land area, acting as a continent, which struggles with religious divide and vested interest from many countries, rendering it extremely difficult to develop even infrastructure, exacerbated by the difficulties of terrain for example, the waterfalls constantly breaking rivers.

WHY DOES ONE DEVELOP FASTER?

China's geography concentrates people, food and power, letting the state plan, build and now project force at sea. Africa's geography disperses and obstructs, and imposed borders turned natural division into conflict. One benefits from great unity and overall interconnectedness whilst the other is caused by divide, because as previously stated the vested interests make it impossible to develop as a continent and it is harder at a larger scale.